

THE WHITE HOUSE

WASHINGTON

MEMORANDUM OF CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Meeting with President Izetbegovic of Bosnia-Herzegovina and President Tudjman of Croatia

PARTICIPANTS: U.S.
The President
Warren Christopher, Secretary of State
Madeleine Albright, U.S. Ambassador to the United Nations
Anthony Lake, Assistant to the President for National Security Affairs
Richard Holbrooke, Assistant Secretary of State for European and Canadian Affairs
Sam Brown, U.S. Representative to CSCE
Victor Jackovich, Ambassador to Bosnia-Herzegovina
Alexander Vershbow, Senior Director for European Affairs, NSC (Notetaker)

Bosnia
Alija Izetbegovic, President
Irfan Ljubijankic, Foreign Minister
Muhammed Sacirbey, Permanent Representative to the United Nations
Mahir Hadziakmetovic, Ambassador to CSCE

Croatia
Franjo Tudjman, President
Mato Granic, Minister of Foreign Affairs
Miomir Zuzul, Ambassador of Croatia to the UN at Geneva
Zeljko Matic, Presidential Foreign Policy Adviser
Dr. Begic, Political Adviser to the President
Interpreter

DATE, TIME December 5, 1994, 1:25 - 1:40PM
AND PLACE: Budapest, Hungary

The President: I am glad to see you. Thank you for coming to this meeting. I wanted to meet so that we could hear your views on the current situation. I asked to see you here together because the integrity of the Federation is very important in maintaining the support of the whole international community for

a just result. I wanted to assure you, President Izetbegovic, that the U.S. has not changed its policy. We are still opposed to any confederation between the Bosnia Serbs and Serbia. We are still ready for NATO to do what it is permitted to do by the United Nations. We still want to be as cooperative and helpful as we can be in bringing about a settlement. I would like to hear from you on your thinking about what is most important. How do you feel about UNPROFOR? Then I would like to hear President Tudjman's views as well. ~~(C)~~

President Izetbegovic: With regard to UNPROFOR, its mission has eroded so much that we are left without UNPROFOR and without weapons to defend ourselves. As you know, we had a choice between maintaining UNPROFOR and receiving weapons (through a lifting of the arms embargo). For the time being, we chose UNPROFOR, but its mission is being degraded. It would be helpful if UNPROFOR could be made more effective. We are looking for UNPROFOR to fulfill its mandate, and nothing more. The paralysis is something that we cannot understand -- first in the behavior of UNPROFOR, and subsequently in the behavior of NATO. The issue is UNPROFOR. We ask that this paralysis be lifted. If this were done, the situation would improve as a consequence. Of course, there would be increased risks for UNPROFOR, but these should be acceptable given the potential benefits. ~~(C)~~

With regard to the situation in Bosnia, we ask that the Serbs accept the Contact Group plan. There are two other ideas which are dependent on a cease-fire. First, a cease-fire throughout Bosnia for a limited period of time could be agreed upon under two conditions: an immediate cease-fire in the Bihac area; and the withdrawal from the Bihac area of the so-called Krajina Serbs. These forces have come to our country from the UN Protected Areas, which are supposed to be demilitarized. Second, if there is a cease-fire in fact, this will normalize the humanitarian aid situation in Bosnia. So far, however, the Serbs have rejected a cease-fire. I just met with British Foreign Secretary Hurd who had met the previous evening with Serbian President Milosevic. Hurd said Milosevic supports these ideas but claimed that he didn't have enough influence on Karadzic. When we talk about Milosevic's influence, it is important that there be no further easing of sanctions, since the only way to get him to act positively is through sanctions. ~~(C)~~

President Tudjman: We have signed an agreement with the Knin Serbs as the second step toward reintegration of the UNPAs. We will now have to see whether this agreement is implemented. If the Knin Serbs fail to implement it, we will not extend UNPROFOR's mandate. Milosevic has the Knin Serbs in his hands. As for the Bosnian Serbs, he does not quite have Karadzic in his hands, but military supplies are still coming into Bosnia from

Serbia. We would therefore appreciate that you not lift sanctions until we see practical achievements, and not just paper agreements, leading to the solution of the occupied areas and to a political solution in Bosnia. ~~(C)~~

The priority issue is the conflict in Bosnia, but here too the key rests in Serb hands. If a firmer line is taken, the Serbs will be forced to accept the Contact Group plan. If the Contact Group took more determined action, such as convening a summit, the West could present a united front to show that Bosnia-Herzegovina exists for the three peoples who live there. This would enable you to avoid a conflict between the West and Russia and also avoid the involvement of Islamic countries, which would have undesirable consequences in terms of increased loss of life and in other ways. Russia obviously wants to preserve its influence in Europe. We should consider this as not a Muslim-Croat, Muslim-Serb, or Croat-Serb problem, but as one of civilization. Any solution involving only UNPROFOR will not work. The Contact Group plan must be carried out to the end and NATO engaged to enforce a settlement. UNPROFOR, with the countries that now form it, has no prospect of success. Therefore, you need to push for a settlement and engage NATO. I would favor increased involvement of NATO at the expense of reducing the number of UNPROFOR troops. ~~(C)~~

The President: President Izetbegovic, you are for a three-month country-wide cease-fire? ~~(C)~~

President Izetbegovic: Yes, on the condition that there is a cease-fire in Bihac and withdrawal of the forces of Krajina Serb leader Martic. ~~(C)~~

The President: During the three months, we will do all we can to support the Contact Group plan. ~~(C)~~

President Izetbegovic: You need to have contacts with the Serbs in the meantime. President Milosevic believes that time is working in his favor. He wants more time to convince Karadzic to accept. But we feel that the Russian presence is behind the latest dangerous Serb actions. Some in the West have concluded that the Russian threat has disappeared, but we in Bosnia still feel it, especially through the presence of surface-to-air missiles. ~~(C)~~

The President: We heard a little of that here today in Budapest. ~~(C)~~

-- End of Conversation --

Clinton Presidential Records Mandatory Declassification Review

This is not a presidential record. This is used as an administrative marker by the William J. Clinton Presidential Library Staff.

Documents from this Mandatory Declassification Review were released in full.
